

a breakthrough in pulses, which are much more nutritious than rice. This requires crop-neutral incentives, meaning pulses and oilseeds should get similar subsidies and market support as rice or wheat get in, say, the Punjab-Haryana belt. Also, much more is required in agriculture R&D. This would also help to promote climate resilience in our cropping pattern as pulses and oilseeds are legumes requiring much less water and fertilisers than rice. Thus, focusing on pulses and oilseeds, as we did on rice and wheat during the Green Revolution days, is essential. It will give us better nutrition with much less damage to groundwater, soils, greenhouse gas emissions and biodiversity.

Thus, we need to move from just food security to nutritional security, especially of our children below the age of five. A significant population of our children (35 per cent) is still stunted (low height for their age). Our research at ICRIER shows that malnutrition in children is not just because of a lack of healthy food, but also due to low education of women (mothers), poor access to sanitation and immunisation. Prime Minister Narendra Modi needs to be commended, for in his first I-Day speech in 2014, he said that he would prioritise building toilets all over the country to give dignity and hygiene to the people. And he did just that. His mega programme of providing safe drinking water to every household, '*Har ghar, nal se jal*', and building pucca houses in rural and urban areas (PM-Awas Yojana), are some other commendable programmes to provide sanitation to all. With these basic programmes in place, and if India can ensure a 7 per cent overall real GDP growth rate (and about 10 per cent in dollar terms), which is very much feasible, India has a chance to become a $30 trillion economy by 2047, with substantial improvement in the economic well-being of its people. That would be a dream come true.

**No complacency:** But all this should not lead to complacency on the agriculture front. Climate change with extreme weather events can give strong shocks to our agriculture. Given that our population by 2050 will be around 1.67 billion, the largest on the planet, we cannot afford to lose focus on food and nutritional security. For that, we will have to rationalise many subsidies, including for food and fertilisers, which amounted to Rs 3.7 lakh crore in the Union budget of Rs 48 lakh crore for FY25. There is scope to save at least 25 per cent of this subsidy amount without adversely affecting the main stakeholders. That money needs to be put in agri R&D, irrigation, water management and rural infrastructure. If we can do that, India can ensure food and nutritional security, and promote inclusive growth for Viksit Bharat@2047. ■

***The author is Distinguished Professor at ICRIER***

*Illustration by* **SIDDHANT JUMDE**